

4, Early States Before The Great Expansion

I believe there is not much need to heavily supplement the process of the first historic leap: the transition from a **pre-state society** (前国家社会) to an **early state** (早期国家).

The only thing that warrants attention is that the specific state of the local society at the exact moment this transition occurs is not absolute; rather, it is possible within a certain spectrum. For instance, whether the society remains completely patriarchal or whether massive remnants of a matriarchal society still survive; whether a relatively complex social division of labor has already emerged or remains ambiguous; and the exact degree of class differentiation.

For civilized societies that enter the **early state** independently (rather than under external influence)—which naturally implies they belong to the earliest batch of civilizations to form—they should already be in a state characterized by patriarchy, a complex social division of labor, and distinct class differentiation on the very eve of this mutation.

Conversely, under the influence of external civilizations, particularly driven by commercial trade, backward pre-state regions might complete this transition much earlier and at a faster pace. A small minority could rapidly amass wealth through commercial activities to become the dominant class. When their **early state** forms, the local social division of labor might still be relatively rudimentary, and even massive traditions of a matriarchal society might be preserved.

However, there is another highly crucial scenario where backward peoples advancing from a **pre-state society** into civilization do not need to pass through a "substantial" **early state** phase. (*An early state here refers to a state where the primary mode of exploitation is the direct expropriation of labor via forced labor, where political power is distributed based on blood ties, and where royal and divine power are tightly intertwined—what we term here a slavery regime*).

This scenario occurs when **barbarians** (蛮族) on the periphery of a classical empire rapidly elevate their **productive forces** and civilizational levels through their interactions with the empire. During their inward migration amidst the empire's declining era, they develop to the point of being capable of establishing feudal relations of production. **These backward peoples, upon "Entering the Pass" (Ru Guan / 入关), will catapult directly into the early stages of a feudal society in a very short timeframe, entirely bypassing the two stages of the early state and the classical empire!**

Additionally, some peoples mastered the skills of metal smelting (bronze, or even later, iron) prior to their formation of a state—for example, the Indo-Europeans roaming the Eurasian landmass. In this case, the historical trajectory diverges somewhat, which will be addressed later.

Obviously, this transition does not *always* occur. **Pre-state societies** were still situated in the Stone Age; their capacity to transform nature and to resist natural fluctuations was exceedingly frail. Due to environmental shifts, many early cultures or civilizations perished. Even a highly mature and prosperous primary civilization like the Indus Valley Civilization could not escape this fate (*though it remains unconfirmed whether the Indus Valley Civilization had already entered a state formation*).

Once social production yields a stable **surplus of social production** (社会生产剩余), as long as this process remains uninterrupted and persists for a sufficient duration, the transition toward an **early state** is bound to happen inevitably.

I find it deeply ironic that although human societies of that era were easily destroyed by nature, they were profoundly difficult to be *self-destroyed*! (Here, "self-destruction" refers to independently prohibiting the possibility of further development, just as the Chinese Empire did; it does not include being eradicated by invading human groups).

This is because the meager **productive forces** back then were fundamentally insufficient to generate any complex social structure capable of acting like the later, phenomenally destructive bureaucratic systems—systems that rendered it almost impossible for the **surplus of social production** to receive any effective investment, and even deployed coercive political power to exterminate any nascent sprouts of change! Even if the magnitude of investment in technology was minuscule, as long as the number of attempts was high enough, probabilistically speaking, the formation of an **early state** was a 100% certainty. After all, compared to the pre-state period, **early states** required no utterly insurmountable technologies; they could both comfortably exist within the Stone Age.

I contend that the evolution from a **pre-state society** to an **early state** should trace a relatively lucid trajectory: *Absence of class differentiation → Emergence of private ownership → Emergence of class differentiation → Formation of the early state.*

There exists no special transitional stage—such as a classical period or an **early modern society** (近世社会)—in between. After all, in the transition from a classless society to a class-based state, let alone lacking any alternation of ruling classes viewed as a macroscopic whole, there are barely even any finely-divided political elite cliques! It is genuinely impossible to imagine under what circumstances a balance could be struck to benefit the monarch (*though at that time, "chieftain" seems a vastly more appropriate title*).

After developing a city-state morphology, individual city-states would indeed occasionally annex numerous surrounding city-states to forge a large kingdom, or even, like Egypt, maintain long-term unification. However, these kingdoms could only sustain stable rule within a tiny minority of intact (*and tightly interconnected*) geographical units—regions characterized by monolithic language, script, and culture. **Their territorial expanse fundamentally could not be compared to that of a typical classical empire.**

The only entity that might provoke skepticism is the emergence of the Inca Empire (印加帝国) in the Andean region. This regime possessed an exceptionally vast territory; in terms of geographical span, it was staggeringly massive. Its population even reached the ten-million mark, encompassing over a hundred distinct languages, and it was hyper-centralized. Judging by these characteristics, the Inca Empire undeniably far surpassed ordinary **early states**, even rivaling typical **classical empires**.

Yet, from another perspective, this so-called empire seemed far more backward than many **early states**! It was stuck in the Stone Age; it possessed no writing system and no currency; commercial circulation was virtually nonexistent; and the state completely monopolized the distribution of social resources. In these aspects, it conspicuously exhibited the characteristics of a much more primitive clan society.

The rise of this regime is indeed difficult for me to comprehend. After all, strictly speaking, directly opposite China (*if one drills straight through the Earth*) is Argentina; Peru and Bolivia are simply too distant from me. Their domesticated crops and animals were completely alien, and a civilization thriving on high-altitude plateaus is excessively unfamiliar to my scope of expertise.

However, from another angle, it must be pointed out that while the Inca state existed for several centuries, the period during which it rapidly ballooned was actually exceedingly brief. Its tenure as the empire stretching 4,000 kilometers seen on modern historical maps lasted mere decades! *Did it truly establish a political system capable of long-term sustainable execution?*

Empirically, effectively altering the consciousness of a nation requires roughly two to three generations. This means that if one or two generations of Inca monarchs could function as leaders with **Charismatic authority**, coupled with certain serendipitous favorable factors (*this is hard to pinpoint—it could be climate shifts, agricultural leaps, or severe internal crises among neighboring states*) and intense military mobilization, they could achieve astonishing military victories in a very short timeframe. Provided they committed no fatal political blunders, it is entirely possible for the regime to sustain itself for a period purely on sheer inertia!

However, what would happen if given a bit more time is highly unpredictable. For instance, the Inca monarch Huayna Capac (瓦伊纳卡帕克), during the empire's absolute zenith, had already made the decision to partition the empire upon his death! Furthermore, even the Spaniards—despite possessing a technological superiority of several generational gaps—heavily exploited the Inca civil war to conquer the nation.

Therefore, one absolutely cannot rule out the possibility that even if this empire had never encountered the Spaniards, it might not have survived for many more years anyway. **Rather than saying the Spanish invasion destroyed the Inca Empire, it is vastly more accurate to say the Spanish invasion destroyed the original Andean society.** Given this context, while the events that transpired in the Inca civilization are bizarre and definitely provoke skepticism, they cannot serve as a potent counterexample to the general rule.

The most ancient batch of **primary civilizations** (原生文明) was born within tropical (or subtropical) climates, including Mesopotamia, Egypt, and the Indus Valley Civilization. These civilizations relied on major rivers flowing through their lands to irrigate the fertile fields along the banks; yet, moving just slightly away from the rivers, the landscape immediately transitioned into barren deserts.

In the very beginning, this geographical layout was immensely hospitable to civilization: abundant water resources, prolonged sunlight, high crop yields per acre, and people were spared from the torment of severe cold. This implies that under identical agricultural technological conditions, these regions generated the highest **surplus of social production** (社会剩余). It is obviously no surprise that they were the first to march toward the stage of **early states**.

Among the **primary civilizations** across the Eurasian landmass, China appears exceptionally unique. Although our civilization evidently emerged later than Mesopotamia and Egypt—roughly contemporaneous with the Indus Valley—it was absolutely not characterized by their "*rivers besieged by deserts*" paradigm! This holds true both for Northern China, which subsequently dominated the mainstream, and for Southern China, which integrated as a tributary.

The primary early crops in Northern China were foxtail millet (粟) and broomcorn millet (黍), both suited for dryland farming. As the staple grains of the northern populace, they sustained civilization through the vast majority of its early epochs. (*The introduction of wheat into China roughly coincided with the dawn of our civilizational history, but it didn't become the primary staple of the North until after the Anno Domini era*).

Another highly probable reason why early Chinese people favored dryland crops was the roaring, catastrophic floods in the North—which is also a shared historical memory across humanity. Not only do historical texts teem with mythological legends of combating the Great Flood, but prehistoric archaeology in China also demonstrates that our nation was severely impacted. Across the entire North China Plain (华北平原)—specifically the regions vulnerable to the "strikes" of the lower Yellow River—there exists a glaring vacuum of prehistoric cultural sites, whereas the surrounding perimeter is densely packed with them.

Whether it was a conscious choice or not for northern residents to farm and dwell on higher elevations, this choice was obviously proven to be phenomenally successful in the end. Because the civilization in the South, primarily cultivating rice (*Chinese scholars have persistently attempted to define Liangzhu [良渚] as a state, as this serves to push China's civilizational history even further back; but I personally find this endeavor lacking in meaning, as everyone knows the Northern civilization ultimately became the mainstream of Chinese civilization*), was evidently severely devastated by the relentless blows of floods and marine transgressions (海侵).

Regardless, **China's primary civilization was evidently born into a geographical location vastly more "open" compared to Egypt, Mesopotamia, and the Indus Valley civilizations!**

After the birth of its **early states**, there existed no insurmountable, "no man's land"-esque barriers nearby. Instead, there were contiguous expanses of regions with similar climates and environments. This dictates that China's **early states** were inevitably forced into far more frequent and "intense" interactions with surrounding tribes and even other early states! (*I use quotation marks here because these interactions were not exclusively warfare; they could also be commerce or other behaviors*).

We shall soon see how exactly this specific "uniqueness" became **the initial perturbation (第一次扰动) that drove China to derail from the normal developmental trajectory of human society**, and exactly how this mechanism exerted its devastating effect!

4, 大扩张前的早期国家

从前国家社会向早期国家转变的第一次历史性飞跃这个过程我认为没有太多需要补充的。唯一需要注意的是，在转变发生的时候当地社会具体处于怎样的状态并非绝对的，而是在一定范围内都有可能。例如该社会究竟是完全的父系社会还是母系社会的残余仍然大量存在，究竟是已经出现了比较复杂的社会分工还是尚不明确，以及阶级分化的程度如何等等。越是独立（而非受外界影响）进入早期国家的文明社会（当然这往往意味着这些文明是形成较早的一批），在变化发生的前夕应当已经是父权制的，具有复杂社会分工的，阶级分化明显的一种状态。在外部文明的影响下，尤其是商业贸易的影响下，落后的前国家地区可能在更早的时候以更快的速度完成这种过渡，少部分人通过商业活动迅速聚敛财富成为占据优势地位的阶级。当早期国家形成的时候，当地的社会分工还较为简单，乃至母系社会的传统仍然大量存留。但是还有一种非常重要的情况下落后民族从前国家社会进入文明状态并不需要经过“可观的”早期国家阶段，也就是以强迫劳动直接剥削劳力为主要剥削方式的，依赖血缘关系分配政治权力的，王权与神权紧密联合的，被我们这里称为奴隶制政权的国家。这种状况就是古典帝国边缘的蛮族在与帝国的交往中生产力和文明水平迅速提升，并且在帝国衰退时期的内迁过程中发展到了可以建立封建生产关系的地步，入关的落后民族就会在很短的时间内直接进入封建社会早期，跳过早期国家和古典帝国两个阶段。另外，一些民族熟练掌握金属（青铜甚至更晚的铁）冶炼的技能要早于其形成国家，例如在欧亚大陆游荡的印欧人，这个时候历史进程会有所不同，稍后将会提及。

这种转变显然不是总能发生，前国家社会尚且处于石器时代，对自然的改造能力以及对自然变化的抵抗能力非常弱。由于环境变化，很多早期文化或者文明消亡了，即使是像印度河文明这样十分成熟和繁荣的原生文明也逃不过，不过尚且不知道印度河文明是否已经进入国家形态。一旦社会生产出现稳定

的生产剩余，那么只要这个过程不间断并且持续的时间足够长，那么像早期国家的转变应当是一定会发生的。我认为讽刺的是，当时的人类社会虽然很容易被自然毁灭，但是却不容易被自我毁灭（这里的自我毁灭是指像中华帝国一样自己禁绝了进一步发展的可能，并不包括被其他人类族群入侵）。这是因为当年贫弱的生产力根本不足以产生任何复杂的社会结构，能够如同后来破坏性的官僚体制一样使得社会生产剩余几乎无法得到任何有效投资，甚至使用强制性的政治权力翦灭一切变化的苗头。哪怕对于技术的投资量很小，但是只要尝试的次数够多从概率上讲形成早期国家可以说是 100% 的事，毕竟早期国家相对于前国家时期并没有什么全然不可克服的技术，它们都可以处于石器时代。

我认为从前国家社会到早期国家，应当沿着没有阶级分化→出现私有制→出现阶级分化→形成早期国家这条比较清晰的链条演化，中间不存在古典时期或者近世时期这样的特殊过渡阶段，毕竟从没有阶级到阶级国家，不要说被视为整体的阶级没有发生交替，甚至连更细分的政治精英团体也没几个，实在无法想象在什么情况下能够达成平衡以使君主获利（不过在那个时候似乎叫酋长更合适）。在发展出城邦形态之后，确实会有个别城邦吞并了周围许多城邦成为一个大王国，甚至如埃及长期维持统一。但是这些王国也只能在少数（还得是紧密联系的）完整的地理单元，语言、文字和文化单一的地域进行稳定统治，幅员远远无法和古典帝国相比。

唯一可能引起怀疑的是安第斯地区出现的印加帝国，这个政权领土非常辽阔，从跨度上讲就更惊人，人口甚至达到了千万级别，并且涵盖了上百种语言，极度集权。从这些特征来看，印加帝国确实远远超过了一般的早期国家，甚至能够和古典帝国媲美。可是从另一方面这个所谓的帝国似乎比很多早期国家还落后，处于石器时代，没有文字，没有货币，商业流通极少，国家主导了社会分配，这里似乎又明显表现出了一种更原始的氏族社会的特征。这个政权的兴起确实是我难以理解的，毕竟严格来讲，中国的正对面就是阿根廷（穿过地球），秘鲁和玻利维亚离我实在是太远了，像这样驯化的作物和动物完全不一样，还处于高原生活的文明对我来说过于陌生。不过从另一个方面又应当指出，印加国家的时间虽然有几个世纪，但是他迅速膨胀的时间其实非常短暂，作为现在历史地图中横跨 4000 公里的帝国只有几十年，它真的建立起一套可以长久实行的政治体制了吗？从经验上看，想要有效地改变一个民族的意识大概需要两三代人的时间，这意味着一旦有一代或者两代印加王能够起到卡里斯玛式领袖的作用，配合一些偶然的有利因素（这个不好说，可能是气候变化、农业进步或者是周边国家出现了严重内部问题），强力的军事动员，如果在很短时间内取得惊人的军事胜利，并且在政治上不犯下致命错误，政权凭借惯性延续一段时间并非不可能。然而时间再久一点会如何变化就难以预料，例如全盛时期的印加君主瓦伊纳卡帕克（Huayna Capac）在去世时就已经做出了分治帝国的决定，而即使是在技术上具有数重代差的西班牙人，在征服这个国家的时候也利用了其内战。因此人们无法排除这个帝国即使没有遇到西班牙人也未必能够再延续多少年的可能，与其说西班牙入侵是摧毁了印加帝国，还不如说西班牙入侵是摧毁了原本的安第斯社会。鉴于这种情况，印加曾经发生的事情虽然奇怪但是也仅仅只是令人怀疑，它并不能作为一个有力的反例。

最为古老的一批原生文明诞生在一种热带（亚热带）的气候中，包括美索不达米亚，埃及还有印度河文明，这些文明依靠流经的大河灌溉两岸肥沃的良田，但是在离河比较远的地方就呈现出了一种荒漠的景观。这种地理格局在最初对于文明确实十分友好，水资源充足，日照时间长，粮食亩产高，人民免于严寒的侵扰。这意味着在同等的农业技术条件下，上述地区的社会剩余最多，显然最早向早期国家迈进也就不足为奇。在欧亚大陆的原生文明中，中国显得极为独特，虽然说我国的文明诞生的明显比美索不达米亚和埃及要晚，与印度河不相上下，但是却远非他们那种“荒漠包围河流”的模式，无论是日后占据主流的中国北方还是作为支流汇入的中国南方。我国北方早期的主要作物是粟和黍，他们都适合在旱地种植，作为北方人民的主粮度过了文明时期的大部分岁月。小麦传入中国的时间与我国的文明史基本相等，但是作为北方的主粮已经是公元之后的事了。早期中国人之所以青睐旱地作物的另一个可能的原因是北方咆哮泛滥的洪水，这也是全人类共同的历史记忆。不仅仅是点击资料上有抗击大洪水的大量传说故事，中国的史前考古也说明我国受到的影响非常大，在整个华北平原，也就是下游黄河能够“打击到”的地区，史前文化遗址出现了明显的空白，而周围一圈都相当密集。无论北方居民选择在地势较高的地方农耕并居住是否有意，但是这种选择显然最终被证明是相当成功的。因为南方主要种植水稻的文明（我国学者一直试图将良渚定义为国家，这样有利于将中国的文明史继续向更早的时期追溯。但我本人认为这种尝试缺少意义，毕竟人人都知道北方的文明后来是中国文明的主流）显然在洪水和海侵的打击下受损十分严重。无论如何，我国的原生文明显然诞生在一片相对于埃及、美索不达米亚和印度河

文明更为“开放的”地理位置，在早期国家诞生之后，附近没有近似于无人区一样难以逾越的屏障，反而是连片的气候环境相似的地区，这意味着早期国家必然要与周围的部落乃至其他早期国家进行更为频繁和“激烈”（打引号的意思是并非只有战争，也可能是商业或者其他行为）的互动。我们很快就会看到，这样一种特殊性成为导致中国偏离正常社会发展轨道的第一次扰动，并且是如何产生作用的。